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unit Renjen, who grew up in Haryana's Rohtak, has touched the pinnacle of

corporate success since he moved to the US some 40 years ago. The CEO Emeritus of Deloitte—who took the consulting giant to the top of the heap of the Big Four as Global CEO and stepped away from the post on December 31—hasn't forgotten his roots; he still maintains a strong connection with Rohtak. In an interview with *Business Today's* Global Business Editor *Udayan Mukherjee*, Renjen talks about the future of Deloitte, the wealth gap, mental health, climate change and the India story. Edited excerpts:

Q: You recently stepped away from your role as Global CEO of Deloitte to continue as CEO Emeritus. Do you feel confident of having armed Deloitte with the tools to maintain its position at the top of the Big Four?

A: It has been quite a journey in an entire partnership spreading across 400,000 professionals to get us to the top of the heap. The credit really belongs to the partnership and to our professionals. It is wonderful to be the No. 1 professional services firm in the world. And as you rightly said, it takes tremendous effort to get to that point, and it takes additional effort to stay at that point. I believe that Deloitte is positioned extremely well. The strategy that we have implemented is still valid and we need to keep executing that. We cannot take our eye off the ball. This is a highly competitive space, and we have to continue to execute. There are no guarantees.

Q: There will be many challenges along the way, including a move globally of separating the accounting and consulting arms of professional services companies like Deloitte, citing competition laws. Is Deloitte prepared for such a potentially disruptive move?

A: Regulators in the UK are talking about operational

separation to ensure we serve our clients, particularly our audit clients, with clear independence and objectivity, and that's exactly what we have been doing. Our audit quality and results cited are testaments to that. We made a decision back in June that we are not going to separate our business and that the multidisciplinary model or MDM is core to our strategy. The private partnership culture is core to Deloitte and has been a key ingredient to our success. So, we are going to persist with this and persist with high audit quality, which is central to who we are, and persist in delivering to our clients and hopefully, as a result, remain anointed the No. 1 firm.

Q: Billionaire investor Ray Dalio recently told us that the wealth gap is one issue which bothers him more than most other economic issues today. In your conversations with large corporations, do things like this come up frequently? Do CEOs recognise the importance of it?

A: When I came to the US 40 years ago, the prevailing wisdom was that the business of business is business—focus on the business fundamentals and leave everything else to the greater society and the community. That has changed. I believe, increasingly, business leaders believe that they cannot be successful if the community that they live in and work in is not successful. So, giving back to the community is incredibly important. At Deloitte, we are focussed on minority communities and getting them to college so that we can reduce the income

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gap through education. Here is the other thing—my most valued asset is my 400,000 professionals. Getting them involved in their own communities is an engagement strategy that is something that they value and commit to. So, we are not just collaborating with other NGOs and putting money in; we are involving our people in this world-class effort. And